

The test won on liquidity. I still said don't ship it.

How a zone-hour courier bonus that worked got killed by its own price tag.

Fictional food-delivery marketplace · synthetic data · real methodology

6 of 12

zones are structurally supply-short.

Demand outruns couriers at peak while other zones sit idle. Customers wait, then bail — ETA climbs and no-courier cancellations rise, at the same time couriers idle in the wrong zones.

Pay a per-delivery bonus in one named zone during the Friday/Saturday peak. See if liquidity improves — and what it costs.

PRIMARY METRIC

Fulfillment rate — share of demand delivered, by zone-day

GUARDRAILS

Incentive cost per incremental order · ETA p50/p90 · no-courier cancel rate · courier earnings/hr · neighbour-zone spillover

Randomized by zone-day, not by customer.

12

ZONES

10

WEEKS

840

ZONE-DAYS, 420/ARM

The intervention is supply-side, so inference runs three ways — cluster-robust, randomization inference, wild-cluster bootstrap — to stay honest about only 12 clusters.

+1.87pp

fulfillment-rate lift · cluster CI [+1.27, +2.46] · $p = 3 \times 10^{-4}$

ETA p90 -6 minutes, no-courier cancels -0.36pp — concentrated in the supply-short and balanced zones (interaction $p = 0.004$).

The lever works. Its price doesn't.

R\$281 per incremental delivered order against a R\$10 contribution margin — fails the guardrail by about 28×. A flat bonus pays every delivery; only ~2% are incremental.

Don't ship the flat bonus. Restructure it to reward incremental supply.

Full methodology, numbers, and code — link in my Featured section.